

McKinsey's Two-Speed Enterprise: The Diffusion Gap, Now With Numbers

The State of AI: Global Survey 2026 — 1,719 respondents, 97 countries, and the first hard cross-section of adoption by company size

May 4 – Jun 8, 2026 — McKinsey fields its annual global AI survey | Aug 25, 2026 — “The State of AI: Global Survey 2026” is published | Aug 26 – Sep 2, 2026 — Trade press coverage frames the headline finding as a “two-speed” enterprise AI market

This document is an archival briefing compiled for the AI Worldview canon, synthesizing McKinsey's “The State of AI: Global Survey 2026” and corroborating reporting by The Register, HPCwire/Alwire, Tech Times, and CX Today (August–September 2026). It is not a verbatim reproduction of the survey; figures are attributed inline. Full source list at the end of this document.

Overview

McKinsey's annual global AI survey, fielded May 4 through June 8, 2026 and published August 25, returned 1,719 responses across 97 countries — the largest and broadest sample this canon has cited from this survey series. Its headline finding sharpens, with hard cross-sectional numbers, a claim this worldview has so far made mostly qualitatively: that the gap between organizations successfully scaling AI and everyone else is widening, and that the gap tracks company size specifically. Trade coverage settled on the phrase “two-speed enterprise AI market” to describe it.

The Gap Between Individual Gains and Organizational Impact

Eighty percent of respondents report that AI has improved their individual productivity. Only 37 percent attribute any EBIT impact to AI at all — essentially unchanged from 2025. “AI high performers” — respondents who attribute at least 5 percent of EBIT to AI use and describe the impact as “significant” — remain flat at just 6 percent of all respondents, unchanged year over year despite a further year of adoption and spending growth. The gap between the 80 percent reporting personal productivity gains and the 6 percent reporting real organizational impact is this canon's “pilot purgatory” belief, quantified at global scale for the first time.

The Two-Speed Divide Tracks Company Size

Among organizations with more than \$1 billion in annual revenue, 40 percent report they are now scaling AI agents, up from 27 percent a year earlier. Among smaller organizations, the figure is 22 percent — flat versus last year. McKinsey reports a parallel pattern specifically in coding agents: roughly 20 percent of all organizations are scaling the technology, versus 31 percent of large enterprises. The report's own framing is that large enterprises, plus a small cohort of high performers of any size, are moving considerably faster than everyone else — and that the gap, rather than closing as the technology matures, grew this year specifically at the large-firm end while stalling everywhere else.

Why This Belongs in the Canon

This worldview's diffusion-gap belief has, until now, rested on qualitative description — that the distance between frontier-lab capability and enterprise deployment is structurally widest in community banking. This survey supplies the first direct, cross-sectional evidence that the gap specifically correlates with organization size, at global scale, in the same year: large enterprises pulled further ahead (27% to 40% scaling agents) while smaller organizations did not move (flat at 22%). For an alliance of community banks — which sit, by

revenue, on the small side of this exact split — that is a direct empirical anchor for the belief that closing the gap collectively is cheaper than each institution closing it alone. It also sharpens the canon's open question on measuring AI ROI: the McKinsey Transformation Manifesto already in this canon reports a 20 percent average EBITDA uplift among 20 companies whose AI transformations delivered — a curated, successful sample. This survey's population-level figure, that only 6 percent of all respondents qualify as high performers, is the denominator the Manifesto's case studies were drawn from. Read together, the two documents say the same thing two different ways: the outcome the Manifesto describes is real, achievable, and rare.

Sources

McKinsey & Company, "The State of AI: Global Survey 2026," published August 25, 2026.

The Register, "McKinsey says enterprise AI is finally 'on the road to ROI'," August 25, 2026.

HPCwire/AIwire, "McKinsey Report: Enterprise AI Is Becoming a Two-Speed Race," August 26 and September 2, 2026.

CX Today, "McKinsey's State Of AI: The Scaling Gap Is Now CX's Problem," September 2026.